franc unrelated to their economic fundamentals; whereas we, in the Reserve Bank, were engaged in preventing a sharp depreciation of the rupee driven largely by economic fundamentals. There is, as I said before, an asymmetry between the two battles. The SNB was in the fray from a position of strength, whereas we were battling from a position of weakness. More importantly, given the external and internal pressures ranged against the rupee—elevated inflation, declining growth, large fiscal deficits and the large and unsustainable current-account deficit—it would have been very unrealistic, if also enormously costly, to draw a line in the sand on the rupee exchange rate. We had necessarily to cross the river by feeling the stones.

What or who exactly is an alpha male? I googled and was baffled by the variation and confusion in the meaning and description of an alpha male. At this point, it is not even clear to me whether I should take not being an alpha male as a badge of honour or as a certificate of weakness. I have decided to let the matter rest. But could I have been more confident, consistent and, importantly, more tactful? With the benefit of hindsight, I can see that I could have done better on all these criteria. Let me illustrate with some examples.

In the post-policy media conference in late July 2013, at the height of the rupee crisis, I had said that the Reserve Bank's actions were not aimed at defending any specific exchange rate, but aimed only at facilitating an orderly adjustment of the exchange rate to its market-determined level. As far as I was concerned, this was just an unequivocal reiteration of the Reserve Bank's standard policy and should not have stirred any reaction. But the markets decided that I had announced an immediate end to all intervention in the market, and reacted sharply. My statement was seen as too dovish, maybe even as too indifferent, and the rupee plunged to a three-week low within hours.

Needless to say, I was quite perturbed by the unsparing market reaction. Was I guilty of fraying market nerves when I should actually have been soothing them? I reflected on this overnight and used the opportunity of the post-policy conference with analysts the following day to get the communication back on track. I asserted that the Reserve Bank would use